

# Connecticut lawmakers call for invoking 25th Amendment to replace Trump; DeLauro says president must be removed ‘immediately’

By ELIZA FAWCETT

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## ***Pastor Carl McCluster Quote Contained Herein:***

***“In this historical moment, we will determine by our responses, whether we stand on the brink of disaster or the bridge of destiny that leads us out of the valley of partisan politics, racial and social injustice and systemic inequity,” Rev. Carl McCluster, Senior Pastor of Shiloh Baptist Church in Bridgeport, said.***

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President Donald Trump delivers an incendiary speech to thousands of his supporters near the White House in Washington, Jan. 6, 2021. (Pete Marovich/The New York Times)

In the wake of the far-right siege of the U.S. Capitol, Connecticut leaders grappled with the violent destruction, incited by President Donald Trump, that engulfed the nation's capital Wednesday. Every member of Connecticut's congressional delegation called for Trump's immediate removal from office — and many were left reeling from the chaos of the previous day.

As the siege unfolded, Rep. Jahana Hayes, D-5th, sheltered in her legislative office with her young son, who was visiting for the day.

“To be locked in my office watching my son's innocence slip away as he realized the Capitol complex was not the secure place he marveled at exploring, to hear him ask ‘are they coming here?’ and for me to have no answer reaffirmed for me that Americans are looking to their leaders for answers,” Hayes said Thursday. “The President cannot be trusted to continue in his role as the protector of our democracy and the official who will respond for our country.”

In a video call of the Connecticut Faith Leaders Collaborative Thursday, Rabbi Jeremy Wiederhorn of The Conservative Synagogue in Westport said that what transpired at the Capitol was “the fruition of activities and actions that, if unabated, will certainly unravel the very fabric of the ‘American Experiment.’ ”

### **‘The president should go’**

Every member of Connecticut's congressional delegation has voiced their support for removing Trump from office before his presidential term officially ends Jan. 20 — though some harbor doubts about the likelihood that Trump's cabinet, or Congress, would approve his removal.

“I support every constitutional effort to remove Donald Trump from office immediately,” Rep. Rosa DeLauro, D-3rd, said in a tweet just hours after the Capitol siege. “The survival of our democracy depends on it.”

New York Sen. Chuck Schumer, the Majority Leader in the next Senate, said Thursday morning that Trump “should not hold office one day longer.” He called for Vice President Mike Pence to “immediately invoke the 25th Amendment” and, if that fails, for Congress to “reconvene to impeach the president.”

The 25th Amendment provides procedures for [replacing a sitting president](#) in the case of death, removal, resignation or incapacitation. If invoked by Pence and a majority of sitting Cabinet secretaries, the amendment would enable the suspension of Trump’s presidential power.

Sen. Richard Blumenthal said in a call Thursday that, like DeLauro, he supports any constitutional efforts to remove Trump. The president, he said, is “unable to discharge the duties of his office,” as well as a “danger to Americans and to American democracy.”

Although proceedings to remove or impeach Trump could begin immediately, Blumenthal said, it is more likely that the president will leave office through “hopefully a transition of power peacefully on January 20th.”

“The president should go,” Rep. Jim Himes, D-4th, said over the phone Thursday. “He should either resign or be removed.”

Himes added that he doubted that a cabinet majority would support invoking the 25th Amendment. If there is accountability, he said, it will likely come when Trump is no longer president.

For Hayes, the issue is not whether an effort to remove Trump from office would succeed — but that an effort must be made to hold the president accountable for what happened in Washington Wednesday.

“To say that we should just wait it out, or for political expediency, do nothing, really abdicates our responsibility. I think we are here today because there has been lack of accountability,” she said. “In the last two weeks of this presidency, [Trump] incited a riot and insurrectionists breached the grounds of this Capitol — for the first time in over 200 years — and desecrated the grounds of the Capitol.”

Sen. Chris Murphy said on a press call Thursday that he is “absolutely supportive” of an effort to invoke the 25th Amendment, adding that Trump is “unhinged, he is unstable, he is angry.”

Murphy conceded that he was skeptical about how successful an attempt to remove the president could be. But he warned that Trump could attempt to rally his supporters for another insurrection — in Washington, D.C. or at state capitols.

“I think it is really irresponsible for people to think of yesterday as some one-off dust-up,” he said.

Calling the insurrection an “attempted coup” for which Trump bears responsibility, Rep. John Larson (D-1st District) questioned whether Trump is mentally fit for office and called on Pence and the cabinet to invoke the 25th Amendment.

Rep. Joe Courtney, D-2nd, argued that the 25th Amendment must be invoked “to ensure the safety of the nation.”

## **Security collapse**

Connecticut lawmakers said they were disturbed by how quickly insurrectionists were able to infiltrate the Capitol and pushed for answers on the security of the complex.

Murphy questioned why it took so long for additional law enforcement to arrive at the Capitol and protect lawmakers, including the three people at the top of the presidential line of succession.

“We shouldn’t have to wait four hours to get [Department of Defense] assistance when the United States Capitol is under attack,” he said.

“There was yesterday a serious and a massive collapse of security,” said DeLauro, who chairs the House Appropriations Committee, which funds the Capitol Police force. The committee is currently investigating the breakdown of law enforcement at the Capitol.

The security response to the breach was “plainly inadequate,” Blumenthal said. While some Capitol police officers acted heroically, he said, the overall response was “lax and lagging.” More troubling, he said, was that the Department of Defense denied requests during the insurgency to activate the National Guard to restore order.

“I’ve talked to a number of my colleagues that the Department of Defense, at the highest levels, was notified about the impending possible attack and assault on the Capitol,” he said. “That kind of information ought to be investigated quickly and effectively by the next attorney general.”

### **‘An unimaginable nightmare’**

Political and religious leaders in Connecticut struggled to make sense of the insurrection that swept through the Capitol Wednesday.

“I was absolutely speechless and floored when I saw that. I just couldn’t believe it,” House Speaker Matt Ritter of Hartford said of the attack. “They got into Nancy Pelosi’s office. They got into the Senate chamber and sat in Mike Pence’s seat. Are you kidding me?”

The violence at the Capitol, Senate President Pro Tem Martin Looney of New Haven said, was “an unimaginable nightmare for the United States of America.”

Some leaders called for unity across party lines and renewed focus on injustice and those in need.

“These recent events should serve as a reminder to my Republican colleagues that though we may disagree at times on policy we, as elected leaders, are ultimately stewards of this great country and answer to the people, not to a party leader,” Hartford City Council President Maly D. Rosado, a Democrat, said in a statement Thursday.

With Democrats poised to take control of the White House, House and Senate, Rosado said she hopes that “we can immediately move to meet the needs of our nation’s residents.” Rosado called for a larger direct stimulus payment and additional shipments of the COVID-19 vaccine to Connecticut.

On the Connecticut Faith Leaders Collaborative call, Rev. Cass Shaw, president of the Council of Churches of Greater Bridgeport, called for a recalibration of the nation’s moral compass, imploring people to “shatter the silence of complicity with the chorus of unity.”

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### **‘I’m ashamed of the Republicans’**

One of Trump’s most vocal supporters in Connecticut, Pastor Will Marotti, was shaken by the violent events at the Capitol. He told his radio audience on WTIC-AM 1080 that he is now considering dropping his political party status as a Republican and becoming an independent voter.

“I may today just go and completely change my political affiliation, and become an unaffiliated voter,” Marotti said Thursday. “I’ve been a Republican my entire life, but I’m ashamed of the Republicans.”

A hard-core Republican, Marotti had incorrectly predicted that Trump would win the election, and he also predicted that Republican David X. Sullivan would defeat Hayes in the 5th district and Republican Margaret Streicker would defeat DeLauro.

Marotti said he foresaw problems because of the long-running, high political tensions in the deeply divided nation.

“I, along with many others, have been warning about this for years — two years at least — saying there would be a boiling point because cooler heads would not prevail, always,” he said. “I don’t know if yesterday was the culmination of frustration and disenfranchisement of two years, four years. Or the beginning of the greater divide within the country. I’m not sure.”

Marotti decried the violence, saying it was not the way to solve political problems.

“It’s not how we act. It’s not how we behave,” he said.

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